

THE PERSON BEFORE THE SPLIT

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Soul-Body Unity and Living Identity

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Abstract

Most philosophical discussions about what it means to be human start after we've already divided mind and body. We set up the problem by separating soul from matter, and then spend all our time wondering how the two could possibly connect. But honestly, that misses something important at the very start. Instead of immediately breaking a person into parts, we should stop and ask what sort of unity even makes those aspects belong together in one living being.

In this paper, I develop an account—grounded in philosophy and Islamic theology—of what I call “living identity.” Here, soul and body aren't duking it out for the right to be called the person. They're distinguishable, sure, but we don't have to pick sides. I'm not trying to infer the existence of an immaterial soul just from watching how our bodies behave. I'm also not offering a clean solution to the old puzzle of how mind and matter interact.

Instead, I try to untangle three questions we usually mush together: What makes us an embodied unity? What keeps us the “same” individual through time? And what holds our moral life and commitments together? Borrowing insights from Descartes, phenomenology, recent work on embodiment, and the Islamic philosophical tradition about self-awareness, I argue that the best starting point is to see the living person as an embodied subject—whose inner and outer life are inseparable parts of a single ongoing existence. In Islamic theology, that unity comes from God, and our responsibility shows up through what we do with our bodies. So, the real question isn't “soul versus body”—it's what it means for a person to be one at all.

Key words: personal identity, soul, body, embodiment, Islamic philosophy, philosophical theology, selfhood, moral integrity

1. Introduction: The Problem May Begin Too Late

The classic mind-body problem always starts the same way—by splitting human existence. We put mind, thought, consciousness, or soul on one side; matter, body, extension, and brain on the other. Then we ask: How do the two get along? Can one be explained in terms of the other? Or does only one side actually exist? It's not that these aren't real questions. They just come a little late. By the time we're asking them, the person has already been pulled apart.

If you look at actual life, it just doesn't work like that. When you meet someone, you see a living being who acts, remembers, suffers, prays, desires, hesitates, answers for choices. Someone grief-stricken speaks in a different voice; shame changes their body language; fear grips the body even before it becomes a clear thought; prayer brings intention together with movement. None of this “proves” substance dualism. A physicalist can describe all this in terms of bodies, and a phenomenologist can describe what it's like to live in a body without invoking the soul. My point is more focused: The experiences that make us ask philosophical questions about persons already belong to a unified living subject. We take that unity for granted before we start breaking it down.

So, what am I proposing? I call it “living identity”—the condition where inner subjectivity and bodily life just are two sides of one concrete human being. This isn’t about reducing personal identity to plain biological continuity, or about saying soul and body are “literally” the same thing. This is about the unity from which we even start to make those distinctions. To make things clear, I sort out three major threads: Embodied unity (the way body and inner life belong together in a living subject); numerical identity (what makes a person the “same” over time); and moral integrity (how a person’s commitments, desires, and actions either hold together or spin apart). They overlap, but we need to keep them straight.

This argument mixes philosophy and theology. Philosophical, because it picks apart our basic concepts, tests what happens when we push them, and compares rival accounts. Theological, because I work explicitly within an Islamic worldview—one where humans are creatures of God, souls are real, actions matter, and resurrection is part of the big picture. I won’t pretend these are “neutral” or “empirical” conclusions. Instead, I’m up front: This is the framework. If you start from that theological picture, what does it mean to take our embodied existence and personal identity seriously?

2. From Distinction to Unity

Descartes often gets dragged into these discussions—fair enough, since we inherited so many of our terms from him. He draws the famous distinction: thinking substance versus extended substance. But it’s too simple to treat Descartes as obsessed only with separation. In the Sixth Meditation, he insists you can’t think of the mind as just a pilot in a ship; actually, bodily sensations show there’s a deep union (Descartes 1641/1996). Recent scholars point out that this isn’t a side note; for Descartes, body-mind unity matters in ordinary life (see Brown and Normore, 2019). So, the real problem isn’t that philosophers ignored unity. It’s that they treat unity as something they have to patch up after dividing things for metaphysical convenience.

Why not flip the order? Instead of starting with separated mental and physical realms and struggling to build a bridge, start with real, living people and ask: What distinctions make sense within that unity? That doesn’t instantly settle whether metaphysics should be dualist, hylomorphic, constitutional, animalist, whatever. It just changes where the burden of proof sits. You can’t just explain how mental stuff causes physical stuff; you also have to account for why pain feels like it happens to “me,” why an intention turns into my bodily action and not someone else’s, and why my body feels like “mine,” not an impersonal tool.

Phenomenology presses this point hard. Merleau-Ponty rejects the idea that the body is just another object in the world. Instead, the body is central to how the subject has access to the world (Merleau-Ponty 1945/2012). Gallagher shows we can’t really talk about consciousness, cognition, or selfhood without believing in the body, with all its distinctions—body image, body schema, movement, action (Gallagher 2005). None of this insists on a metaphysical soul. The key thing is, embodiment is philosophically primary. You need it just to get a “person” in the first place—it’s not some accident after the real metaphysics happens.

That’s the insight I’m hanging onto, while avoiding the trap of reducing everything to one side. The human person isn’t a ghost in a shell, and not just a cleverly wired machine either. In the theology I’m working with, soul and body are genuinely distinct, but here in worldly life, they form the condition where one subject acts and answers for its life. The body isn’t packaging or decoration, and the soul isn’t just a label for passing awareness. It’s more accurate to start with this unity, rather than grinding away about which “side” is really the self.

3. Living Identity and the Question “What Are We?”

Personal ontology today helps clarify why this matters. Olson pulls apart the question “what are we?” from the mind-body problem or the issue of persistence (Olson, 2007). You can have a theory that explains what sorts of beings have thoughts, without explaining how we persist through change. Baker’s constitution view shows that identity isn’t the only metaphysical relation for connecting persons and bodies (Baker, 2000). What these discussions reveal is that we constantly collapse different questions under one word: identity.

That’s why “living identity” isn’t meant to be a new technical fix for numerical identity. It’s a way to describe what it’s like to be a person here and now. We don’t encounter a person as an itemized list. The same subject who raises a hand decides to do it; the same one who’s publicly shamed looks down in embarrassment, and whoever gets hurt feels the wound as happening to them. In ordinary life, what’s inward and what’s bodily describe the same underlying person. The trick is to explain that convergence, not to toss out one description or the other.

Let me frame it more clearly: Embodied unity is about what connects intentions, actions, feelings, and bodily states in one subject at a given time. Numerical identity is across time—what makes the subject at one moment the same as before. Moral integrity is about coherence—do the person’s judgments, desires, and actions line up, or pull apart? You can stick together as the “same” person even if your moral life shatters. You can go through wild bodily change and still be the same individual. It’s when people confuse these relations that the debates get stuck.

This distinction also protects against an easy objection. If I say “soul plus body equals living identity,” that’s just shorthand. It’s not a claim that they’re mathematically identical or that we just add two whole persons together. What I mean is, in ordinary life, people are embodied subjects. I’m not claiming to know if the soul is a substance, form, emergent property, whatever—that’s a further argument for another time. What I’m saying here is simple: don’t treat embodied unity as a surface illusion, or as something that only shows up after metaphysics have already decided everything.

4. Self-Awareness, Soul, and the Islamic Philosophical Background

Islamic philosophy has always wrestled with the relation between self, soul, and body. Avicenna’s flying-man thought experiment is famous—it imagines a person dropped into existence without sensory contact or bodily awareness, and shows that even then, self-awareness is left over. In his psychological writings (see Rahman’s translation, Avicenna 1952), Avicenna says the soul is what makes “I” possible. More recent scholarship (Kaukua 2015) has shown that this wasn’t just some odd argument for dualism, but part of a bigger view about selfhood. The upshot: You can separate awareness-of-self from awareness-of-the-body, at least in thought.

But we shouldn’t force phenomenology and Avicenna together too early. Avicenna shows why you can’t just collapse selfhood into body-representation. Phenomenology, on the other hand, shows ordinary agency demands embodiment. These tensions are valuable: The self can’t be reduced to just a physical object in public space, but lived human life is always embodied.

The Qur’an adds another layer. It describes humans as created, embodied, accountable, and destined for death and return. It speaks of God taking souls at death (Qur’an 39:42), and bodily resurrection (Qur’an 75:3-4, 36:78-79). I’m not using these as proof texts in a secular argument—they simply set the theological frame. Any philosophical account given from this place has to take both soul and body seriously; you can’t just preserve one by tossing the other out.

You see this tension especially in the debate about resurrection, as explored by al-Ghazali. He wants to know: What has to persist if a resurrected person is to be the same as before, and not just a replacement? But he also insists bodily resurrection matters (al-Ghazali 2000). So, Islamic theology always had a personal identity problem, not simply a doctrine about substances. If bodily life matters for the answer to “what is a human being?”, then embodiment can’t be treated as just accidental, even if the soul survives apart from the body.

5. The Body as Expression, Not Evidence

It’s tempting, whenever we talk about soul-body unity, to race from bodily signs straight to metaphysical conclusions. Sure, tears, trembling, prayer, posture—those all show we’re embodied. But none of that, by itself, proves the soul is immaterial. Physicalists, dualists, you name it—everyone can explain these behaviors differently. So, we shouldn’t treat every detail of normal experience as “evidence” for our metaphysics.

The stronger, safer claim is just descriptive: The body is how the person shows up. Promises come via speech, intentions become real through movement, shame changes how we stand, discipline shapes practice and attention. Bodily expressions matter, but they’re not metaphysical trump cards. They show us how persons exist and act, not what substances exist.

This is close to the point made in embodied cognition and phenomenology. Gallagher shows bodily structures shape thinking and action, but that doesn’t make us “just” bodies (Gallagher 2005). Merleau-Ponty’s lived-body idea resists treating the body as a detached object (Merleau-Ponty 1945/2012). The theological view can take on these insights, but push further: Bodily life belongs to a subject whose reality isn’t used up by what you can see from the outside.

So, we hold off reduction on both sides. Against some externalist view: The body isn’t just matter arranged in human form, it’s the lived set of possibilities for acting in the world. Against an internalist view: The soul isn’t the whole human being in isolation. In worldly life, personhood is about vulnerability, physical location, gesture, habit, responsibility—all done in a body. Persons are inward, but not invisible; embodied, but not exhausted by the outside.

6. Moral Integrity and the Unity of Agency

This third relation—moral integrity—shows why the language of unity can’t be left to metaphysics alone. People often feel conflict between what they think is right and what they want to do. In Islamic moral thinking, we talk about nafs, desire, temptation, discipline—this is the territory. But not every conflict is about soul “versus” body. The person stays one subject. What changes is whether agency holds together.

Moral fragmentation happens when someone keeps acting against their commitments, or when desires, judgments, and actions aren’t lined up anymore. I’m not saying that appetite is, by itself, bad. Hunger, attraction, fear, fatigue, involuntary bodily reactions—these aren’t sins just by existing. What matters is how the person engages them and what choices they make. That distinction is key if we want a moral psychology that doesn’t blame people for being embodied.

The body here is central. Moral agency is embodied agency. Whether it’s a gaze, a word, restraint, violence, charity, prayer—it’s not just what you meant inside, it’s what you did in the world. Qur’anic language links knowledge, hearing, sight, action, and responsibility. For instance, Qur’an 17:36 ties sensory faculties to accountability. This doesn’t create a neat theory of personal ontology, but it supports the theological claim that what we do with our bodies is part of being answerable.

So, moral integrity is about agency, not numerical identity. If you break a promise, you're still the same person who made it—and responsibility depends on that continuity. Moral failure wouldn't make sense if every internal conflict created a new subject. Fragmentation is about whether one agent lives in a coherent or divided way. That's why talking about unity versus fragmentation is more illuminating than just pitting soul against body. The most difficult conflicts are inside one life, not between two substances.

7. Objections and Limits

Some objections are obvious. First, someone might say this is just verbal—redescribing what ordinary life already shows, but dodging the big metaphysical questions. That's right, to a point. I'm not solving the contest between different metaphysical systems, or proving anything just from observation. The main thing here is untangling questions that usually get mixed up, and arguing that lived unity deserves explanatory pride of place. It's a clarification, not a final answer—but that can still reshape the debate.

Second, a physicalist might answer: "Well, I can explain all your cases without invoking God or souls." Sure, you can. Grief, posture, prayer—they can all be described in physical terms. So these are examples, not evidence for supernatural claims. The real argument is about what ultimately belongs in an account of persons, not whether bodies do things.

Third comes the question about living identity and the soul after death. If we say the person is the soul-body composite, what should we say about what survives after bodily death? Does the person go out of existence until resurrection, or does the same subject keep going in a different mode? This is a real problem—one that's puzzled philosophers and theologians alike. For instance, Van Dyke, on Aquinas, points out how tricky it is to maintain identity when the composite disappears, even if the soul remains (Van Dyke 2007). I'm not pretending I've fixed this here, only that sorting out the basic distinctions is the necessary groundwork for whatever comes next.

8. Conclusion: Start With the Person

So where does that leave us? Not with a finished theory of the soul, and definitely not with a neat formula that settles the mind-body problem. What I think we do get is a better place to begin. Before asking how two different things interact, we should notice that the human being we are trying to explain already lives as one subject. Pain, intention, memory, worship, embarrassment, responsibility—these don't arrive in separate boxes. They happen in one life.

That is why I have kept embodied unity, numerical identity, and moral integrity apart. They answer different questions. Embodied unity is about how inner life and bodily life belong to one person here and now. Numerical identity is about what makes that person the same one across change. Moral integrity is about whether that same person's judgments, desires, and actions hold together. Mixing them up makes the argument look simpler than it really is.

Within the Islamic frame of this paper, soul and body both matter. The soul can't simply be reduced to whatever the body is doing at a given moment, but the body can't be treated as disposable packaging either. We act through it, we become recognizable through it, and we're accountable for what we do with it. Death and resurrection make the identity problem harder, not easier, and that problem deserves its own argument rather than a quick answer tucked into the end of this one.

My claim, then, is modest. Philosophy doesn't have to begin by choosing a winner between soul and body. It can begin one step earlier, with the person who is already living the problem. The split may still matter. But the person comes first.

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